

Alligator mississippiensis

American alligator



Length 9¼–16 ft
(2.8–5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



Once widely hunted for its skin, the American alligator became seriously endangered in the 1950s, but under legal protection has staged a strong recovery. A large, powerful reptile, it is black with a broad head and rounded snout, and has a heavily plated back. It also has a characteristic large fourth tooth that fits into a socket in the upper jaw. This alligator feeds in or near fresh water, taking animals of all kinds,

including birds snatched from low branches. During the breeding season, the males roar to attract females, and mating takes place underwater. Each female lays 25–60 eggs in an enormous nest made of vegetation and mud, digging it open when she hears the calls of the hatching young; she may stay with her brood for as long as 3 years.

ALLIGATOR HOLES

The American alligator prefers to float, partially submerged, in lakes, swamps, and marshes. In midsummer, as the water table falls, it retreats into “alligator holes”—keeping a small body of water open by digging out the sand or mud at the bottom. It feeds on fishes that are trapped in the diminishing pool and animals that visit it.



THE BLACK ALLIGATOR

Both adult and juvenile American alligators are black, but the juveniles have bold, yellow crossbands.

webbed feet for swimming

keeled scales on tail

Caiman crocodilus

Spectacled caiman



Length 6½–8 ft
(2–2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

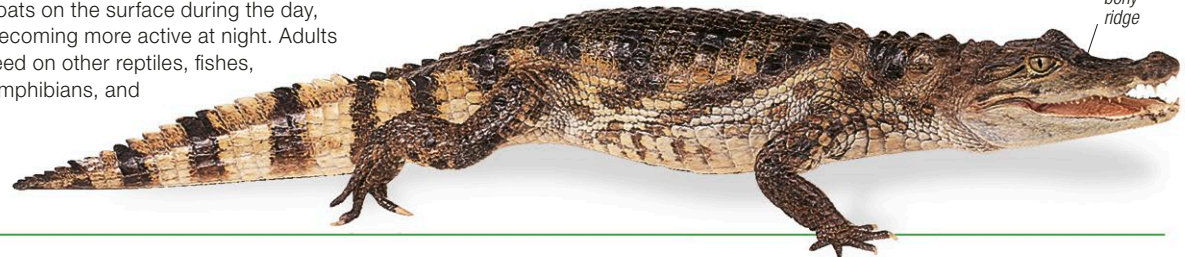
Location Central America,
N. South America



Also called the common caiman, this dull olive crocodilian has a bony ridge in front of its eyes. It is found in most freshwater habitats, rarely leaving the water unless driven out by drought, when it will burrow into the mud. It floats on the surface during the day, becoming more active at night. Adults feed on other reptiles, fishes, amphibians, and

waterbirds. Males are territorial and establish a dominance hierarchy. Females lay 14–40 eggs in mounds of decaying plants and soil at the edge of water, or on rafts of floating vegetation. Several females may share

the same nest and guard it against predators. Although heavily hunted for its skin, this crocodilian has benefited from artificial bodies of water, such as reservoirs, resulting in increases in local populations.



bony ridge

Crocodylus niloticus

Nile crocodile



Length 11 ft (3.5 m),
max 20 ft (6 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

Location Africa,
W. Madagascar



The Nile crocodile has a dark olive to gray body with darker crossbands. It favors larger rivers, lakes, and swamps, and is also found in estuaries and river mouths; it may come ashore to bask on hot days. It feeds on fishes, antelope, zebras, and even buffaloes,

leaping up to snatch nesting birds or pull drinking animals into the water. Although solitary by nature, several crocodiles may congregate for feeding, working together to herd fishes into shallow water, where they are easier to catch. Males are territorial and establish a dominance hierarchy. The female lays 16–80 eggs in a hole dug on a bank well above the water level and uses the same nest site for the whole of her life. She guards the eggs throughout the incubation period. The young chirp when they are about to hatch and the female digs them out, gently maneuvering the hatchlings into her mouth, and carrying them into the water in batches. They remain together for 6–8 weeks, then gradually disperse. For the first 4 or 5 years they live in burrows up to 9¾ ft (3 m) long.

JAWS AND TEETH

The Nile crocodile has long jaws, with teeth that are exposed even when its mouth is closed. Like other crocodilians, it can bite but it cannot chew, which presents problems when dealing with large prey such as zebras and buffaloes. Nile crocodiles deal with these by dragging them underwater, and then spinning around to tear off chunks of flesh.



eyes on top of head

dark crossbands on body

bony, platelike scales

pair of raised keels down tail

powerful tail for swimming

AQUATIC ADAPTATIONS

Like most crocodiles, the Nile crocodile has eyes and nostrils on the top of its head, helping it to see and breathe in water; it also has a flat, powerful tail and webbed hindfeet that help it to swim.